

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: North

Board: 3

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: East

Board: 5

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: South

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ A 9 5 2

♥ 4 2

♦ 9 8 6 4

♣ A K J

♠ 8 6 3

♥ A K Q J 9 7 5

♦ A K

♣ 7



♠ Q J 7

♥ 8 3

♦ Q J 10 2

♣ Q 9 5 2

♠ K 10 4

♥ 10 6

♦ 7 5 3

♣ 10 8 6 4 3

West

North

East

South

4♥

All Pass

4♥ by North

find a way to hold the ♠ losers to 2. The obvious possibility is for East to hold the ♠ A and you lead through him to make the ♠ K a winner. That's a 50% possibility.

But you can improve on that a little bit. If East holds both the ♠ Q J you could make a deep finesse of dummy's ♠ 10 and West would have to play his ♠ A to win the trick. And if it didn't work and West won with a lesser ♠ you would still have time to play toward the ♠ K.

Win the ♦, pull trumps, lead the ♠ 3 to dummy's ♠ 10.

You can see that the deep finesse would indeed force West's ♠ A. However, East played his ♠ Q to the trick, forcing you to go up with dummy's ♠ K, which was taken by West's ♠ A.

You must modify the Plan a little bit. Now your only hope is that East still holds the ♠ J. So you win the next trick in your hand and lead a ♠ toward dummy's ♠ 10. This time East is caught. He plays the ♠ J hoping you had a doubleton, but you still have a ♠ to get to the now high ♠ 10.

One school of thought says to open 2♣ with a hand that is within one trick of game, even though the point count is below 22.

Another school of thought says to go ahead and bid the game, hoping to keep the opponents away from any competition.

Today you take the second and bid 4♥.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♦ Q.

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Losers: ♠ 3 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 1 : Total = 4

You are going to lose the ♣ for sure, so you need to find a way to hold the ♠ losers to 2. The obvious possibility is for East to hold the ♠ A and you lead through him to make the ♠ K a winner. That's a 50% possibility.

Board 3

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ 8
 ♥ A 4
 ♦ A K 8 7 3
 ♣ A 10 9 6 5

♠ J 10 5 4 2

♥ K 7

♦ Q 5 4

♣ K J 7



♠ 9 7
 ♥ Q J 10 9 6 5 3
 ♦ 6 2
 ♣ Q 3

♠ A K Q 6 3

♥ 8 2

♦ J 10 9

♣ 8 4 2

West

North

East

South

3♥

Pass

4♥

All Pass

4♥ by East

You are very weak. But you are also not vulnerable.

So with 5 playing tricks you leap to 3♥. Partner raises to 4♥ and you pass.

East plays 4♥. South leads ♠A, then ♥8.

East plays 4♥. South leads ♠A, then ♥8.

Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 1 : Total = 4

You've already lost 1 ♠, you can't escape the ♣ and it looks like the ♥ is unavoidable also. So that means you can't afford to lose that second ♠.

If you play dummy's ♥4 North will win the ♥K and play another ♥. You will lose that second ♠ and go down 1.

Instead you should rise with dummy's ♥A, play ♦A, ♦K and then a small ♦ which you ruff. Now play your ♠9 and ruff with dummy's last trump.

Usually it is a good play to let a lead come up to your Queen. It's like a free finesse.

But you don't want to get into the habit of doing what is **USUALLY** good without thinking through the consequences.

Board 5

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q 9 7 5 3

♥ K 9

♦ 9 6 3

♣ J 10 4

♠ A J 6

♥ Q 7 3

♦ Q 8 5 2

♣ 7 6 2



♠ 8 4 2

♥ A J 10 6 4

♦ K J 10

♣ 5 3

♠ K 10

♥ 8 5 2

♦ A 7 4

♣ A K Q 9 8

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South

Assuming the ♣s behave you need to get one more winner. It's possible you could lead toward dummy's ♦Q but even if it works they would probably attack ♥s. Your best chance of getting an extra trick lies in the ♠ suit.

It is almost certain that West holds the ♠Q. Of course defenders sometimes don't lead according to the guidelines, but if East had the ♠Q he would likely have played it at the first trick. In addition, the Rule of 11 tells you there were 6 cards in the North, East and South hands higher than the ♠5. You can account for all of them, so West must have the ♠Q. In that case you can assure the contract by winning the first trick with the ♠K rather than the ♠10. In this way you will be able to gain a trick by finessing West for the ♠Q. It's true that if you won with the ♠10 you would still have both the ♠K and ♠A remaining, but you wouldn't have the dummy entry you needed.

With the unfortunate placement of red cards the only way you can enjoy 3 ♠ tricks is to take your ♠K on the first trick and later finesse West for the ♠Q.

Notice how strange this game can be. If your holding was ♠ K 2 rather than ♠ K 10 you would have had no difficulty coming up with the correct play. But the fact that you can win a cheap trick with the ♠10 tries to lure you into making an inferior play.

With a balanced, 17 point hand you open 1NT. Partner responds 2NT.

You were invited to bid 3NT if you have a maximum opener. With 17 points you accept the invitation.

South plays 3NT. West leads ♠5. You put on dummy's ♠6 and East plays the ♠8.

South plays 3NT. West leads ♠5. You put on dummy's ♠6 and East plays the ♠8.

Winner count: ♠ 2 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 5 : Total = 8

The good news is that they didn't lead a ♥. The bad news is that if you give up the lead they probably will.